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LOCAL STORIES AUGUST 26, 2022

Meet Agustin Rosa

VoyageBaltimore

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Today we'd like to introduce you to Agustin Rosa.

Hi Agustin, thanks for sharing your story with us. To start, maybe you can tell our readers some of your backstories.
When I was a little kid, my favorite activity was reading. I grew up in a busy urban area in Santa Fe, Argentina. My source of books back then was a second-hand store where you could bring back the books you already read in exchange for store credit. The store was huge and poorly organized, and I read a bit of everything. It wasn't long before I started asking my parents for little notebooks and filled them with fantastical, surreal stories based on whatever I was reading. When I moved to New York City for college, it felt natural to study writing. I began by making wallpaper poems–not meant to be read but simply looked at. If words and signs are used to map out our reality, I wanted to warp that reality by playing with language through visual means.

This was during the early days of Web 2.0. Netflix had just started streaming movies in the browser, and I felt inspired to engage the web as my first medium for this project. Poetry could be interactive. Stories could look nothing like stories. Rather, they could be cut-up poems

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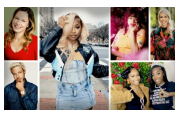
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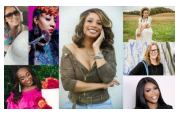
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rendered through pop-up windows. They could look like a random grid of black and white squares that slowly resolved into a series of days—the same number an average person lives out. A story can be grown like a garden. Jorge Luis Borges likened a book to a "garden of forking paths," mixing different traditional and experimental techniques; my garden is shaped like a labyrinth, inviting the reader to unlock its riddles. I have always gravitated toward growing my community. In 2016 I founded Dead Alive Press (**https://deadalivepress.com**), an experimental press and online space that explores new ways of telling stories through technology and collaboration. Six years later, I feel lucky it has allowed me to collaborate with dozens of artists and writers worldwide.

Can you talk to us about the challenges and lessons you've learned along the way? Would you say it's been easy or smooth in retrospect?

The year 2020 took me by surprise. At the beginning of the year, I was suddenly let go from my job. I used this as an excuse to try living out my dream of being an artist full-time. I left my apartment and Baltimore behind and started to apply to every opportunity I could find. It was a hard few months, but I could not have foreseen the beginning of COVID. Immediately I found that most art residencies and institutions were closing their doors, and many opportunities were canceled. I found myself without a place to live and bounced around the US for a year. This was a tough transitional time until I found my way back to Baltimore and my art practice.

Appreciate you sharing that. What else should we know about what you do?

I am a writer, editor, and artist. I am mostly known for my writing and digital art, but I also just exhibited my first major body of physical work, MUTANTE_CHITECTURE, an exhibition of interactive and wearable objects. The show is based around the word "mutante", the Spanish word for mutant. For this exhibit, I was interested in exploring different transformations of space and our bodies. The gallery's center was occupied by "mutante architectures," floating sculptures made of bamboo and thread that respond to touch by spinning, twisting, and unfolding. The audience

part of the show, I also facilitated a series of community workshops for making "mutante capes," colorful garments that are meant to transform the body and encourage new types of play. I often present my work unfinished in a way that requires the audience to enter into collaboration with the artist and the materials. In this way, I imagine transformation as a collective activity. After the show was over, people could either put their capes back or take it home with them. Although it was good for the show that I kept a few capes around, I was happiest when I saw one of them in the real world. I still receive pictures of people walking and dancing around town with their capes. Sculpture, performance, and sewing were all new for me, and the process of getting the show together was equally exciting, exhausting, and terrifying. But I loved the collaborative and community energy and can't wait to keep exploring these new techniques and ideas.

Are there any important lessons you've learned that you can share with us?
– The importance of community. Often artists and writers are depicted as solitary creatures, but I found that my work does not feel complete until it interacts with my community.
– The power of participation. Living in a society that favors images, videos, and a passive audience makes it hard to underestimate the connection created by touch and direct participation.
– Leaning on those who came before. For me, this is my parents and the artists and writers from Latin America who wrestled with similar themes and concerns in the past. Learning about their footsteps helps clarify my path.

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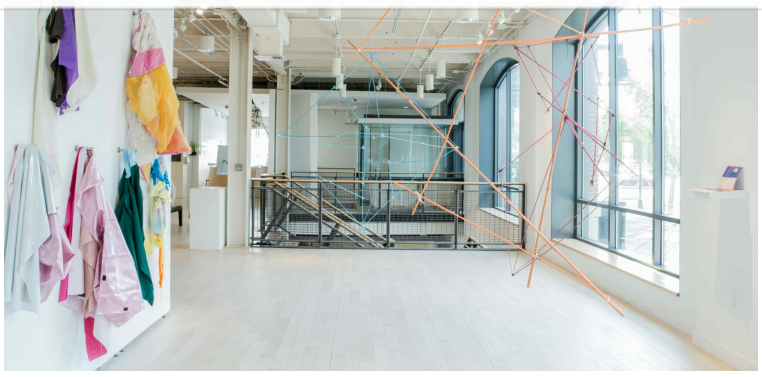

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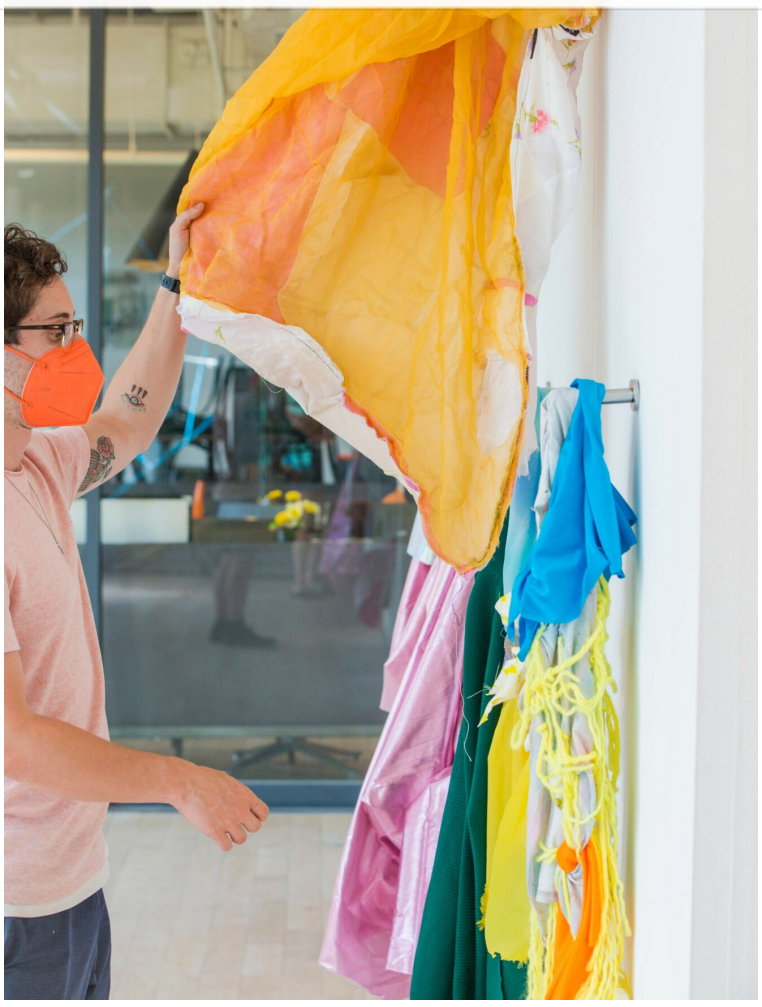

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